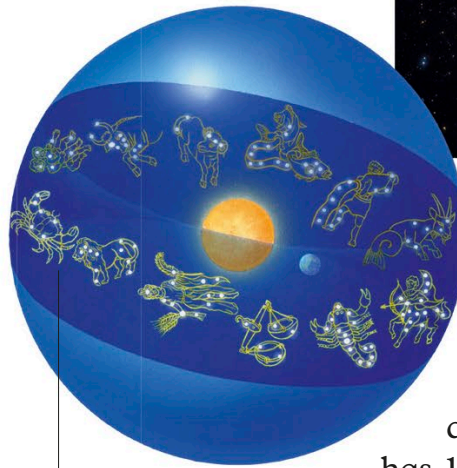
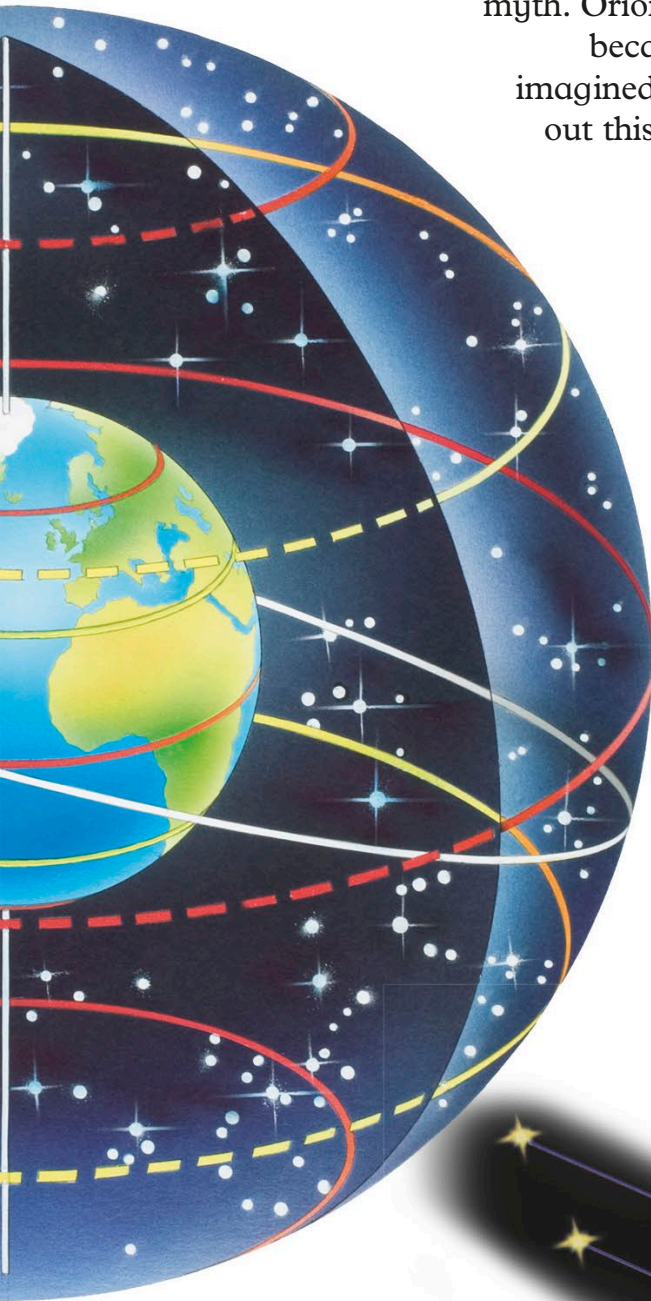
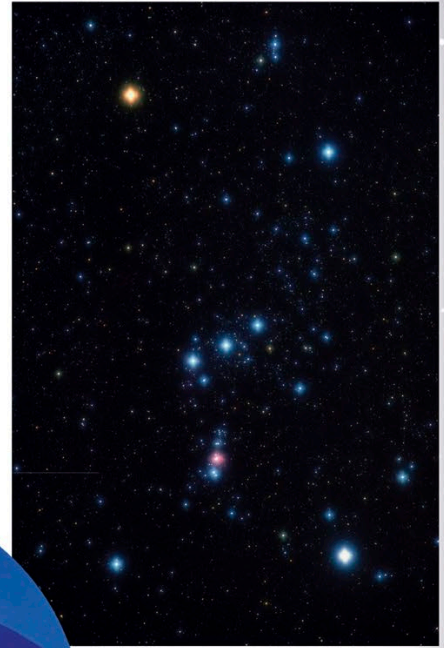


What's the story?

Many constellations were named after characters in ancient Greek myth. Orion (seen here) was named because ancient astronomers imagined two lines of stars picked out this hunter's belt and sword.



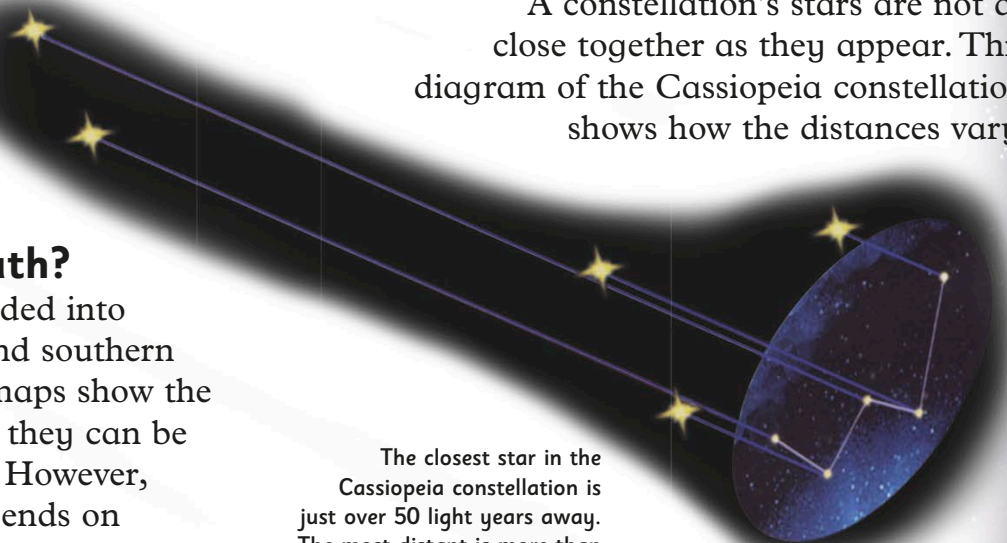
The 12 constellations of the zodiac lie on an imaginary band in the sky.

The zodiac

This is an imaginary band within which the Sun, Moon, and planets appear to travel. The band has 12 divisions, and each part is a constellation. The name zodiac comes from the Greek word *zōidiakos* which means “circle of animals”, although not all 12 are animals.

Close neighbours

A constellation's stars are not as close together as they appear. This diagram of the Cassiopeia constellation shows how the distances vary.



The closest star in the Cassiopeia constellation is just over 50 light years away. The most distant is more than 600 light years away.

Are you north or south?

The sphere of the sky is divided into two halves – the northern and southern celestial hemispheres. Star maps show the location of constellations as they can be seen from each hemisphere. However, which stars you can see depends on where you live on the Earth.